

Herbārium — a downland week of worts

Companion to Aurōra; a gift, outside the numbering. Dated prīdiē Nōnās lūliās MMXXVI (6 July). Seven plants for seven days, lore labelled real or imagined. Not a dosing guide — Sunday's plant is deadly.

Wort = OE *wyrt*, a plant (as in St John's wort; nothing to do with warts). The week itself is Roman — diēs Lūnae → Sōlis — with Saxon gods swapped in for four of the seven (Tiw for Mars, Woden for Mercury, Thunor for Jupiter, Frige for Venus). Saturn alone kept his English job.

The seven

Day	Plant	Binomial, parsed	Kept for
Diēs Lūnae · Mōnandæg	Yarrow	<i>Achillea millefolium</i> — Achilles' thousand-leaf (mille + folium)	Soldier's woundwort; staunching and nosebleed divination; I Ching stalks. Real part: genuinely astringent, field first aid from Troy to the gunpowder era by reputation.
Diēs Mārtis · Tīwesdæg	Self-heal	<i>Prunella vulgaris</i> — vulgāris "common", 3rd- decl adjective (fortis family)	Heal-all, carpenter's herb; doctrine of signatures read the hooked flower as a billhook. Real part: harmless, ubiquitous, trusted with everything anyway.
Diēs Mercurī · Wōdnesdæg	Wild thyme	<i>Thymus polytrichus</i> — "many-haired"	Fairy plant of the chalk; thymon ↔ thyein (incense) or thymos (courage). Real part: crowns yellow-meadow anthills = turf unploughed a century+ = conditions under which ramparts survive. An instrument.
		<i>Hypericum perforatum</i> — perforātum "pierced"	Midsummer sun-herb; mediaeval name <i>fuga daemonum</i> , flight of

Diēs Iovis · Punresdæg	St John's wort	through" (hold a leaf to the sun); hypericum, one account: hyper + eikōn, hung above images against spirits	demons. Real part: modern trials show effect on low mood — and therefore real drug interactions. Admire in the field; dosing is for people with lanyards.
Diēs Veneris · Frīgedæg	Meadowsweet	<i>Filipendula ulmaria</i> — ulmāria "elm-like"; filipendula "hanging by a thread" (from cousin dropwort's tubers)	Meadwort (the mead, not the meadow); Elizabeth I's strewing herb per Gerard; one third of Blodeuwedd. Real part: found in Bronze Age burials; and Spiraea ulmaria → salicylic compounds → Bayer 1899: a-spir-in .
Diēs Saturnī · Sæternesdæg	Elder	<i>Sambucus nigra</i> — nigra "black"; sambūcus kin to the sambūca, a stringed instrument	Elder Mother — ask before cutting; unlucky furniture, protective at the door. Real part: cordial excellent, raw green parts mildly toxic; flags disturbed enriched ground — badger setts, warrens, sometimes older disturbance. On a barrow, an elder is information.
Diēs Sōlis · Sunnandæg	Yew	<i>Taxus baccata</i> — baccāta "berried"; taxus ↔ Greek toxon (bow) → toxikon pharmakon, arrow-poison → toxic	Kingley Vale: ancient yews below, Devil's Humps Bronze Age barrows above; legend gives the grove Viking ghosts. Churchyard yews often argued older than their churches. Real part: every part deadly except (arguably) the red aril flesh — the seed inside is worst. Admire; don't taste.

Wortcunning

Cockayne's 1860s edition of the OE medical manuscripts: *Leechdoms, Wortcunning and Starcraft of Early England* — medicine, plant-lore, star-lore on one spine. Centrepiece: the **Nine Herbs Charm** (Lacnunga) — *Gemyne ðū, mucgwyrt, hwæt þū āmældodest* ("Remember, mugwort, what you declared") — with Woden striking the adder into nine with nine glory-twigs. Christian manuscript, heathen god, herbal remedy, one breath.

Writing plants as power is old: migration-era bracteates carry runic **laukaz** ("leek") and *alu* as amulets — the written name *was* the charm. Script on skin works in that tradition.

Letter	Name	Plant	Note
ᚷ	beorc	birch	futhorc; Rune Poem: shining branches, crown touching sky
ᚦ	þorn	thorn	futhorc; "exceedingly sharp, evil for any thegn to touch"
ᚱ	ēoh	yew	futhorc; "rough without, hard and earth-fast, keeper of fire"
ᚦ	āc	oak	futhorc; feeder of pigs, timber of ships
ᚹ	beithe	birch	ogham; first letter, first tree
ᚼ	dair	oak	ogham; secure among genuine tree-names
ᚾ	coll	hazel	ogham; wisdom tree of the Irish tales

Honest note. The complete ogham "tree alphabet" is a mediaeval schoolroom construction over an older script — only some letter names (birch, alder, oak, hazel among them) are securely trees; the rest were reinterpreted, plus poetic kennings (Bríatharogam). Lore layered on lore: stratigraphy, in a hillside or an alphabet.

Placement precedent, for what it's worth: apotropaic charms sat at thresholds — throats, wrists, lintels. Boundaries.

The monitor's eye (for August 7th)

Monitoring generally = repeat visits, fixed-point photos, condition forms, an eye for change. Vegetation as instrument:

Sign	Reading
Thyme, salad burnet, rockrose in short turf	Unimproved chalk grassland — unploughed centuries; earthwork-friendly conditions
Yellow meadow anthills	Long-undisturbed grassland; good news wearing thyme
Nettle patches	Nutrient enrichment — dung, burrow spoil, sometimes old occupation
Elder on a mound	Disturbed enriched ground — setts, warrens
	Rabbits/badgers; setts-in-barrows is the sector's chronic

Fresh chalk spoil, burrows	headache (both protected, they disagree)
Bare scars, braided paths	Foot/hoof erosion — caught by photo comparison
Small neat holes, sometimes backfilled	Nighthawking (illegal detecting) — record and report, never confront

Villain with folklore: **hawthorn** — the fairy tree spared on mounds for fear of consequences, and simultaneously the chief scrub destroyer of downland earthworks. The lore isn't always on our side.

Fixed-point photography = paradata discipline by another name — the exact documentation habit flagged as the gap before presenting photogrammetry work.

Envoi

Diēs longus est — sed collēs manent. In collibus herbae sunt; inter herbās flōrēs; in flōribus nōmina antīqua. Nōmina eārum iam legis. Hoc satis est. Bene ambulā, amīce.

The day is long — but the hills remain. On the hills there are worts; among the worts, flowers; in the flowers, ancient names. You now read their names. That is enough. Walk well, friend.

New word	Meaning	Hook
manent	they remain	manēre → permanent, mansion
herba	plant, wort	herb; this book's title
legis	you read	legere → legible, lecture; regis pattern
satis	enough	satisfy, satiate
bene	well	benefit; adverb of bonus

Botanical Latin is Latin. One wort a day is the whole discipline.